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Fragments in AEM



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1



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In Adobe Experience Manager (AEM), “fragments” primarily refer to two distinct but related concepts: Content Fragments and Experience Fragments. Both are powerful tools for managing and reusing content, but they serve different purposes and are optimized for different scenarios.

Let’s break down each type:

1. Content Fragments

Purpose: Content Fragments are designed for structured content and headless delivery. They allow authors to create and manage text-based content in a structured, channel-agnostic way, separating the content from its presentation.

Key Characteristics:

- **Structured Content:** They are based on Content Fragment Models, which define a specific schema (e.g., “News Article” with fields for “Title,” “Author,” “Body,” “Publication Date,” “Image Reference”). This ensures consistent content structure.
- **Headless/Omnichannel:** Ideal for delivering content to various channels beyond traditional AEM web pages, such as mobile apps, IoT devices, single-page applications (SPAs), or other external systems. They can be exposed via the AEM GraphQL API.
- **Pure Content:** Primarily focus on text, numbers, dates, and references to assets (like images or videos) — not on layout or design.
- **Content Variations:** Support creating different “variations” of the same content (e.g., a “short” variation for a mobile app and a “long” variation for a web page).

- **Associated Content:** Can link to or embed other assets (like images from AEM Assets) or even other Content Fragments.
- **Management:** Created and managed in the AEM Assets console, often under `/content/dam/fragments`.

When to use Content Fragments:

- You need to reuse content across multiple channels (web, mobile, IoT, etc.).
- You're implementing a headless or hybrid CMS architecture.
- You require highly structured content that can be programmatically accessed and rendered differently on various platforms.
- You want to manage translations of structured content effectively.

Example Use Cases: Product descriptions, author bios, news articles, FAQs, legal disclaimers, event details.

2. Experience Fragments (XF)

Purpose: Experience Fragments are reusable content and layout components that define a complete “experience” or a section of a page. They are designed for on-page, visual reuse and consistency across traditional AEM websites.

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Key Characteristics:

- **Content + Layout:** Unlike Content Fragments, Experience Fragments contain both content *and* the associated layout (HTML, CSS, JavaScript). They are essentially a collection of AEM components arranged in a specific way.
- **WYSIWYG Editing:** Created and edited using the standard AEM page editor, allowing authors to visually compose and arrange components.
- **Reusable Blocks:** Intended to be reused as complete blocks or sections within different pages or across various channels (like email campaigns or third-party sites via their HTML/JSON renditions).
- **Variations:** Support creating different “variations” of an experience (e.g., “Desktop Hero,” “Mobile Hero,” “Email Header”) to cater to different contexts or channels.
- **Automatic Renditions:** AEM can automatically generate different renditions of an XF (e.g., HTML, JSON, plain text) which makes them adaptable for various consumption methods.
- **Integration with Target:** Can be easily integrated with Adobe Target for A/B testing or personalization.
- **Management:** Created and managed in the AEM Experience Fragments console, typically under `/content/experience-fragments`.

When to use Experience Fragments:

- You need to reuse specific page sections or content blocks that include layout and styling (e.g., headers, footers, call-to-action sections, product showcases).

- You want to ensure visual consistency across multiple pages or even different websites.
- You need to provide a curated “experience” block for marketing campaigns or personalization efforts.
- You want to syndicate a fully rendered HTML section to external systems (e.g., injecting a promo block into an email).

Example Use Cases: Common website headers/footers, “About Us” sections, “Contact Us” blocks, promotional banners, product feature lists, customer testimonials.

Summary Table:

Feature	Content Fragments	Experience Fragments
Primary Focus	Structured Content (Content First)	Content & Layout (Experience First)
Content Type	Pure text, numbers, dates, asset references	A collection of AEM components with content & layout
Editing	Fragment Editor (form-based)	Page Editor (WYSIWYG)
Reusability	Across channels (headless, mobile, web)	Visually on pages, campaigns, external systems
Output	Data (via GraphQL, JSON)	Rendered HTML, JSON
Management	AEM Assets Console	AEM Experience Fragments Console
Use Case Example	Product description for web, mobile, and print	Reusable hero banner for homepage and landing pages



Fragments is crucial for designing efficient and scalable content management strategies in AEM.

Aem



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